Boundary-Setting Scripts Library

Sixteen ready-to-adapt scripts for work, family, friendships, and relationships, plus a space to write your own.

WORK

Declining extra work

“Thanks for thinking of me. I’m at capacity this week, so I can’t take this on and do it well. If it can wait until [date], I’d be glad to look then.”

Messages outside working hours

“I’ll reply to non-urgent messages during working hours so I can give them proper attention. If something is truly urgent, please call.”

Pushing back on an unrealistic deadline

“I want to deliver this well. With the current scope, [date] isn’t realistic. I can deliver [part] by [date] or the full version by [date]. Which works better?”

Being interrupted or talked over

“I’d like to finish my point, and then I’d be glad to hear your thoughts.”

FAMILY

Declining a visit or event

“I love you and I’m not able to make it this time. I’d like to catch up another day. Would [day] work?”

Unsolicited advice

“I appreciate that you care. I’m working through this myself, and what would help most right now is just listening.”

Topics you don’t want to discuss

“I’m not going to talk about that. Tell me about [something else] instead.”

Lending money or being relied on repeatedly

“I can’t help financially this time. I care about you and I’m happy to help you think through other options.”

FRIENDSHIP

Declining plans

“Thanks for the invite. I need a quiet night this week. Could we plan for [day] instead?”

A friend who always vents

“I care about what you’re going through. I don’t have the capacity to talk through it tonight. Can we talk tomorrow?”

Cancelling at the last minute (you)

“I’m sorry for the short notice. I’m not up to it tonight, and I’d rather be honest than push through. Can we reschedule?”

Feeling consistently one-sided

“I’ve noticed I’m usually the one reaching out. I’d like our friendship to feel mutual. Can we talk about it?”

RELATIONSHIPS

Needing alone time

“I love spending time with you, and I need some time alone to recharge. I’ll be glad to reconnect afterwards.”

Raising a recurring issue

“When [specific thing] happens, I feel [feeling]. What I need is [request]. Would you be open to that?”

Disagreeing calmly

“I see it differently, and I’d like to understand your view. I’d also like to share mine.”

Pausing a heated conversation

“I want to talk about this and I’m too upset to do it well. Can we take twenty minutes and come back?”

My own scripts

Situation and script 1:

Situation and script 2:

Situation and script 3:

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